



CONSUMER BEHAVIOUR INSIGHTS

Decoding Consumer Decisions

“Qualitative Dive Across Price & Involvement Levels”

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1. Introduction

Consumer behaviour, at its core, is about understanding why people do what they do when they spend money. That question sounds deceptively simple, but as this project taught us, the reality is far more layered. This report is the outcome of Group Project A03 for the Consumer Behaviour Insights course, where our team set out to examine how real people make purchase decisions across three very different types of products.

We structured our research around three categories. The first Category A covers everyday, low-cost purchases under INR 200: the kind of thing you buy almost without thinking. The second Category B covers high-value purchases above INR 10,000 made primarily because you need them to function, not because they say something about you. The third Category C, which covers high-value purchases above INR 10,000 where the product itself becomes a statement, a reflection of who the buyer is or who they want to become. These three categories were not chosen arbitrarily.

Together, they represent the full range of how involved a consumer gets in a decision, from grabbing a juice at a mart without a second thought, to spending months researching a television, to saving up for years to buy the one laptop you have always wanted.

To gather our data, we conducted six telephonic depth interviews, two per category, with people outside our course who had recently made a qualifying purchase. What we found surprised us in some ways and confirmed established theory in others. Not every high-value purchase is driven by identity. Not every low-value purchase is mindless.

And the role of family, peers, and social networks in shaping what Indian consumers buy is more powerful than any advertisement.

The goal of this report is not simply to describe what six people bought. It is to decode why, and to translate those findings into something a marketing manager can actually use.

2. Methodology

For this project, we chose to go with qualitative research, specifically telephonic depth interviews. The reason was straightforward. When the goal is to understand why someone bought something, a survey with tick boxes simply does not get you there. You need a conversation. You need to be able to ask a follow-up when someone says something interesting, or slow down when they mention something they had not planned to say. That is what depth interviews allow, and that is why Schiffman, Wisenblit and Kumar (2019) position them as one of the most valuable tools available for uncovering the real drivers behind consumer decisions.

We conducted six interviews in total, two for each of the three product categories. All six respondents were people outside our course who had made a relevant purchase within the last three months. The interviews were done over phone calls, each lasting roughly ten to fifteen minutes. We used a semi-structured format, which means we had a prepared set of questions to keep things consistent across all six conversations, but we also gave ourselves the freedom to dig deeper whenever a respondent said something unexpected or particularly revealing. Some of the most useful insights from this study came from those unplanned moments.

Our respondents came from our personal and professional networks. We were conscious about not interviewing the same type of person six times, so we made sure there was a reasonable spread in terms of age, occupation, and life situation. Every interview was conducted with the respondent's awareness and consent, and we transcribed the responses as soon as each call ended to ensure accuracy.

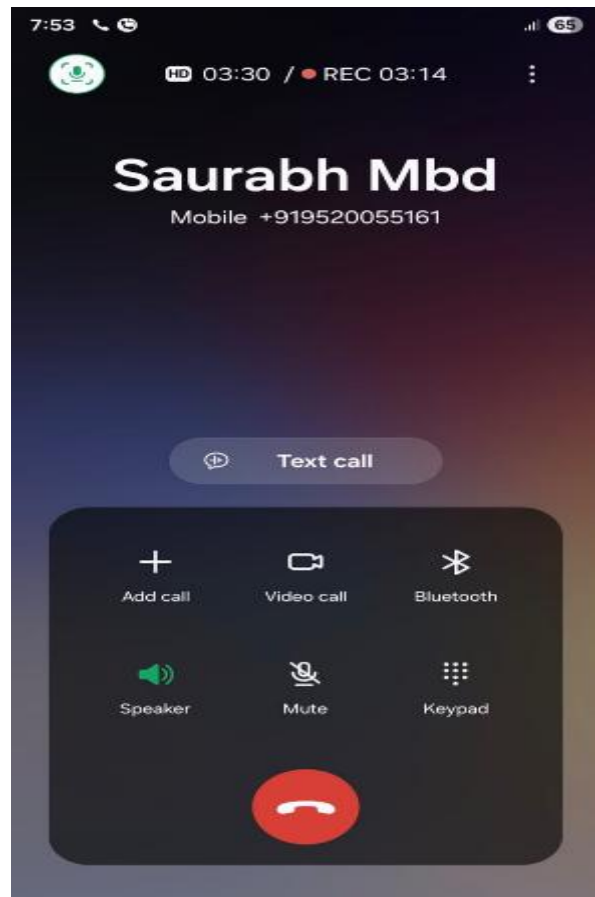
The questions we asked were built around the assignment brief, but we added our own probing questions wherever we felt the standard list would not surface the full picture. Our overall framework was the five-stage consumer decision model described by Mothersbaugh, Hawkins and Kleiser (2020), which covers problem recognition, information search, evaluation of alternatives, the purchase itself, and post-purchase behaviour. Once all six interviews were done, we analysed them in two ways. First, we looked at each interview on its own to identify what internal and external factors were driving that specific consumer. Second, we looked across all three categories to find patterns, contrasts, and insights that no single interview could reveal on its own.

3. Individual Interview Summaries, Category A

Category A covers low-involvement, routine purchases under INR 200. Consumer behaviour theory suggests that decisions in this category are characterised by habitual problem-solving or, in some cases, immediate situational responses, with minimal cognitive effort devoted to information search or evaluation of alternatives (Mothersbaugh et al., 2020). The two respondents in this category presented a particularly interesting contrast one a highly habitual buyer and the other a purely situational, emergency purchaser.

3.1 Interview 1, Saurabh Singh Tomar

Field	Details
Respondent	Saurabh Singh Tomar
Product	Tropicana Juice (1 litre)
Price	INR 160–165
Category	Category A, Mundane Product
Decision Type	Habitual / Routine Purchase
Key Driver	Brand preference + store proximity



Saurabh's purchase of Tropicana juice offers a textbook illustration of habitual buying behaviour, which consumer behaviour scholars link directly to operant conditioning. Having repeatedly purchased Tropicana and experienced consistent satisfaction, Saurabh has been reinforced to select the same product without fresh deliberation a pattern Schiffman et al. (2019) describe as a conditioned response developed through positive reinforcement over time. What makes this case particularly interesting is that Saurabh does engage in a minimal degree of evaluation he consciously compares Tropicana and Real Juice yet almost always arrives at the same conclusion. This reflects what Solomon (2020) terms an 'inertia' purchase pattern, where the appearance of choice masks what is functionally a habitual decision.

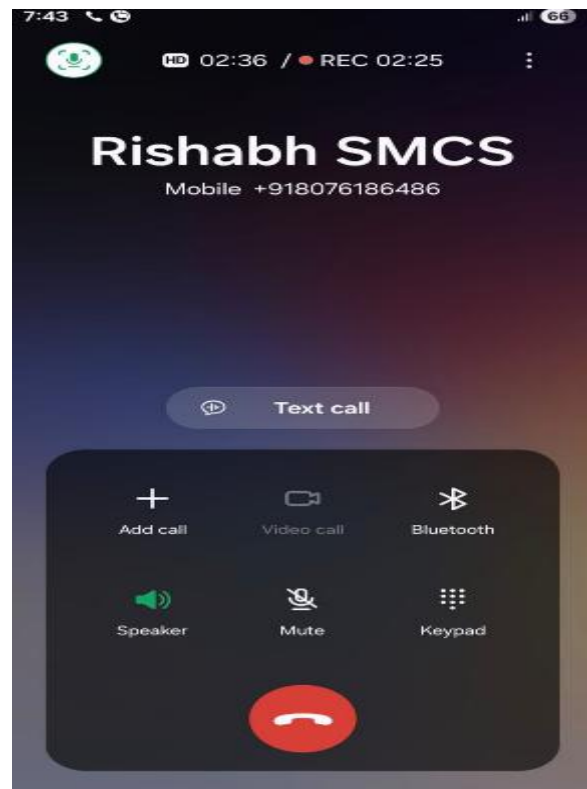
The role of the store is equally significant. Saurabh explicitly states that the purchase is largely location-triggered, passing the mart prompts the purchase rather than a pre-planned need. This insight has direct implications for point-of-purchase strategy: for Category A brands, shelf visibility and store proximity function as the primary 'triggers' in the problem recognition stage. The consumer does not arrive with a felt need; the environment creates the need. Maslow's hierarchy is relevant here, the purchase addresses a physiological need (hydration), which means once triggered, motivation to buy is immediate and requires no further persuasion.

Internal Factors: Habitual attitude, brand preference (Tropicana over Real), positive reinforcement through repeated satisfaction, physiological motivation.

External Factors: Store proximity and location serve as environmental triggers; no social influence identified.

3.2 Interview 2, Rishabh Sharma

Field	Details
Respondent	Rishabh Sharma
Product	Slippers
Price	INR 200
Category	Category A, Mundane Product
Decision Type	Emergency / Situational Purchase
Key Driver	Urgent need + nearest available outlet



Rishabh's purchase of slippers at a railway station presents a sharply contrasting case to Saurabh's habitual buying. Here, the decision was not driven by habit or brand preference but by an acute situational need, he was wearing shoes on a train journey and required slippers before boarding. The decision-making process was compressed entirely into a single moment: problem recognition and purchase occurred almost simultaneously, with no information search, no evaluation of alternatives, and no brand consideration whatsoever. He picked up the first available pair from the nearest stall.

This behaviour is consistent with what Mothersbaugh et al. (2020) call 'nominal decision-making' or 'routine problem-solving,' where low involvement and high urgency combine to eliminate deliberation entirely. The Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM) is instructive here, in situations of high situational pressure and low motivation to process information, consumers default to peripheral cues such as physical availability rather than central evaluation of product attributes (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986). Rishabh did not consider whether the slippers were of good quality or whether another stall might offer a better option, proximity was the only criterion.

The contrast with Saurabh is analytically important. Both are Category A purchases, yet the psychological processes are entirely different. Saurabh's purchase is driven by a conditioned habit loop; Rishabh's is driven by an acute situational trigger. For marketers, this distinction matters: Saurabh can be retained through consistency and availability, while a Rishabh-type consumer can be captured purely through strategic placement at high-traffic transient locations.

Internal Factors: Urgent physiological need, zero deliberation, no brand attitude involved.

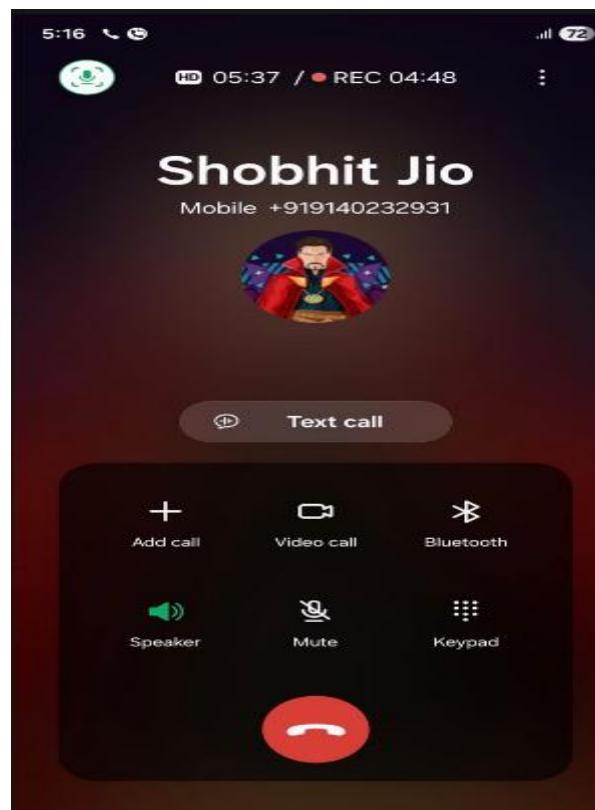
External Factors: None, purely individual situational decision driven by physical location.

4. Individual Interview Summaries, Category B

Category B captures high-involvement utilitarian purchases above INR 10,000. Unlike Category A, consumers in this segment engage in what Mothersbaugh et al. (2020) term 'extended problem-solving,' involving deliberate and often extensive information search, systematic evaluation of multiple alternatives, and careful consideration of post-purchase factors such as warranty and service support. Both respondents in this category demonstrated this pattern, though the nature and channels of their information search differed meaningfully.

4.1 Interview 3, Shobhit Singh Tomar

Field	Details
Respondent	Shobhit Singh Tomar
Product	Sony Bravia 2 Series LED Television
Price	INR 58,000 (MRP INR 62,000)
Category	Category B, Utilitarian Product
Decision Type	Extended Problem-Solving / High Involvement
Key Driver	Picture quality + value-for-money + joint family decision



Shobhit's purchase of a Sony Bravia television is one of the most comprehensively documented decision processes in this study. As a newly married individual setting up a new home, the purchase of a television represented a considered household investment. The problem recognition was deliberate, the absence of a television in the new home created a felt need, and the subsequent decision process spanned over two months, encompassing online research, physical store visits to Croma and Sony showrooms, and a direct comparison between Sony Bravia 2, Sony Bravia 3, LG, and Samsung models.

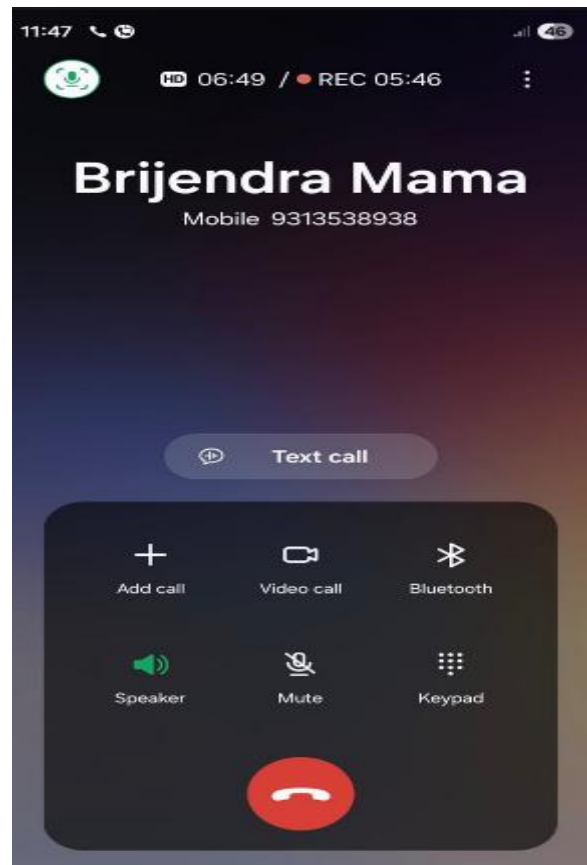
The Tri-Component Attitude Model (Schiffman et al., 2019) is highly applicable here. Shobhit's cognitive component was strong, he evaluated multiple brands on technical attributes including colour accuracy, pixel quality, and screen type. His affective component was grounded in the tangible experience of viewing the products in-store, where the Sony's picture quality made a superior impression. The conative component manifested in the final purchase act, notably executed on Amazon after confirming that the price was lower than in-store. This hybrid channel behaviour, physical evaluation followed by online purchase, is a growing pattern in Indian consumer behaviour and presents a significant challenge for brick-and-mortar retailers.

The role of Shobhit's wife as a co-decider is also noteworthy. This reflects a shift in Indian household decision-making patterns, where high-value domestic purchases are increasingly joint decisions rather than being driven by a single family member. Over one year after the purchase, Shobhit reports complete satisfaction and no cognitive dissonance, a strong indicator that the extended deliberation process served its risk-reduction function effectively.

Internal Factors: Functional attitude toward Sony brand, quality perception, rational multi-attribute evaluation, value-consciousness.

External Factors: Wife as co-decider, in-store product demonstration, online price comparison served as information sources.

4.2 Interview 4, Brijendra Singh Tomar



Field	Details
Respondent	Brijendra Singh Tomar
Product	Whirlpool Fully Automatic Washing Machine
Price	INR 25,000
Category	Category B, Utilitarian Product
Decision Type	Extended Problem-Solving / Word-of-Mouth Driven
Key Driver	Brand reputation + trusted personal recommendations

Brijendra's purchase of a Whirlpool washing machine provides a fascinating study in the power of personal reference groups as information sources, particularly in the context of Indian family structures. The decision emerged from a newly felt household need, the family had been managing without an automatic washing machine, but increasing domestic workload made it a practical necessity. Unlike Shobhit, who relied heavily on digital research and store visits,

Brijendra's information search was almost entirely interpersonal, anchored in conversations with close relatives who already owned Whirlpool machines.

This behaviour aligns closely with Reference Group Theory as outlined by Schiffman et al. (2019), where informational social influence, seeking guidance from credible personal sources, plays a dominant role in high-involvement purchase decisions. The fact that multiple trusted people in Brijendra's circle endorsed the same brand removed the need for comparative evaluation almost entirely. Whirlpool's consistent positive word-of-mouth effectively pre-empted the alternative evaluation stage of the decision process. This is a powerful illustration of how opinion leadership within a social network can compress what might otherwise be a lengthy decision into a relatively quick one.

The channel choice, local store rather than online, was determined not by preference but by product availability, as the specific model was not listed on any e-commerce platform at the time of purchase. This is a distribution insight that Whirlpool and similar brands must take seriously: in semi-urban and smaller city markets, offline availability remains a decisive purchase driver, and gaps in online inventory can cede ground to competing brands. Post-purchase confidence was high, consistent with the reassurance derived from trusted social endorsement.

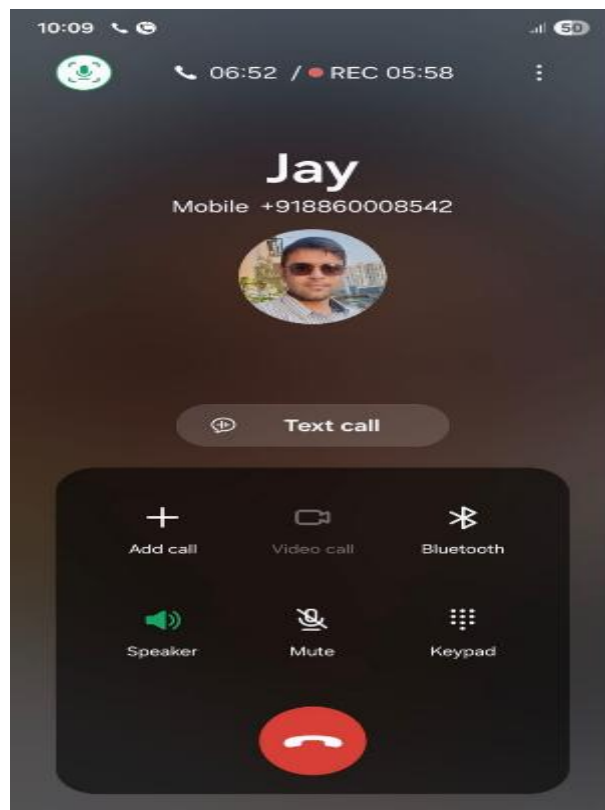
Internal Factors: Brand trust, perceived reliability, risk-reduction motivation, practical utility focus.

External Factors: Family and close relatives as primary opinion leaders, word-of-mouth as dominant information channel.

5. Individual Interview Summaries, Category C

Category C covers purchases above INR 10,000 that consumers associate with personal identity or self-expression. Consumer behaviour theory, particularly Sirgy's (1982) Self-Concept Theory, proposes that consumers choose products whose perceived image is congruent with their actual or aspirational self-concept. Both respondents in this category made high-value purchases, yet interestingly, neither framed their decision in explicitly identity-driven terms, a finding that deserves careful analytical attention.

5.1 Interview 5 , Jay Kishan Singh



Field	Details
Respondent	Jay Kishan Singh
Product	Apple MacBook Pro
Price	INR 1,80,000
Category	Category C, Identity Product
Decision Type	Aspirational / Long-Term Planned Purchase
Key Driver	Functional aspiration + professional peer influence + financial readiness

Jay Kishan's purchase of an Apple MacBook Pro at INR 1.8 lakh is perhaps the most analytically rich case in this study, precisely because it challenges the expected framing of Category C purchases. When asked whether the purchase was motivated by how others would perceive him, Jay Kishan explicitly and emphatically denied a status-driven motivation. He described it as 'a good investment, not a status symbol,' grounded in the technical superiority of macOS, battery life, processing speed, and the Apple ecosystem. Yet the very features he cited, premium pricing, brand exclusivity, and professional peer ownership, are the markers that consumer behaviour theory identifies as identity-signalling attributes (Solomon, 2020).

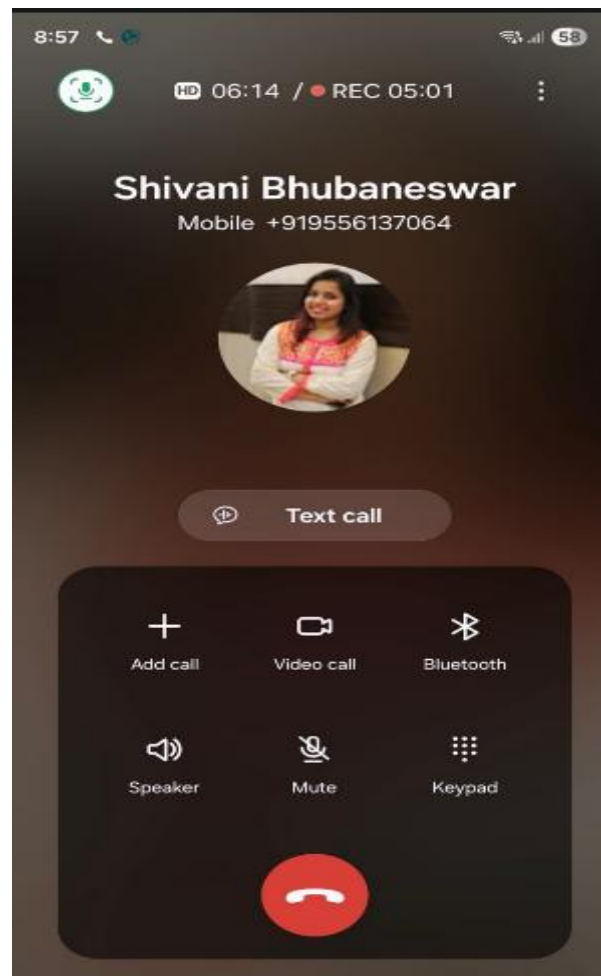
This tension between stated functional motivation and implicit identity signalling is a recurring and well-documented phenomenon in consumer psychology. Consumers frequently rationalise identity-driven purchases in functional terms as a means of resolving the cognitive dissonance between self-perception as a rational buyer and the emotional reality of aspirational consumption. Jay Kishan saved money specifically for this purchase over three to four years, a level of sustained financial commitment that goes far beyond what a purely utilitarian purchase would warrant. The fact that he showed the MacBook to his family as a 'personal achievement' further confirms the symbolic, identity-affirming dimension of the purchase, even if he does not consciously categorise it as such.

The influence of his developer peer group is also a classic example of informational reference group influence, where credibility of the source, not merely the social desire to conform, drives the decision. This aligns with Schiffman et al.'s (2019) distinction between informational and normative social influence, suggesting that Jay Kishan's decision sits at the intersection of rational evaluation and aspirational identity, making him a particularly nuanced consumer profile.

Internal Factors: Long-term aspiration, professional self-concept, intrinsic motivation (achievement), functional product attitude.

External Factors: Developer peer group as credible opinion leaders, family as validation reference group.

5.2 Interview 6, Shivani Singh



Field	Details
Respondent	Shivani Singh
Product	Vivo X200 Smartphone
Price	INR 65,000
Category	Category C, Identity Product
Decision Type	Specification-Driven / Patiently Planned Purchase
Key Driver	Camera capability + family reference + in-store comparative testing

Shivani's purchase of the Vivo X200 at INR 65,000 in December 2025 presents a different dimension of Category C consumer behaviour. Like Jay Kishan, she denied that external perception drove her decision, stating it was 'purely for me.' Yet her decision process was deeply shaped by a family member who already owned the same product, whose photography output she had personally observed and been impressed by. This is a textbook example of what

Schiffman et al. (2019) call 'primary reference group influence', where close family members, rather than aspirational figures or celebrities, serve as the most trusted source of product information.

What distinguishes Shivani's decision is the remarkable patience demonstrated in her purchase timeline. Upon learning that a new model was forthcoming, she waited six months rather than purchasing the existing version, a decision that reflects high product involvement and what consumer researchers describe as 'anticipatory socialisation,' where consumers defer gratification in order to acquire the ideal version of a desired product. This level of planning and patience is rarely seen in Category A purchases and even in some Category B decisions, underscoring the unique psychological depth of identity-category purchases.

Her in-store research methodology was also notably rigorous, she physically tested and photographed subjects using iPhone, Samsung, OnePlus, and Vivo X200 side by side, ultimately selecting the product that delivered the best photographic output in her own hands-on evaluation. The iPhone was dismissed not on capability grounds but on price and operating system preference, reflecting a pragmatic, specification-led evaluation overlay on what remains, at its core, an identity-adjacent purchase. Her continued satisfaction, every photograph she takes reinforces the purchase decision, illustrates sustained post-purchase consonance driven by daily functional confirmation of the original choice.

Internal Factors: Camera quality perception, product-specific functional attitude, patience and delayed gratification, Android ecosystem preference.

External Factors: Family member as primary reference group, in-store physical demonstration as key evaluation tool.

6. Thematic Analysis: Internal and External Factors

A cross-category analysis of all six interviews reveals a rich landscape of internal and external influences that shape consumer decisions at each price and involvement level. Rather than operating in isolation, these factors interact, sometimes reinforcing each other, sometimes creating tension, producing the complex, contextually embedded decision processes documented in this study. The table below provides a consolidated view of the key internal and external factors identified across all six respondents.

Respondent	Category	Internal Factors	External Factors
Saurabh Singh Tomar	Category A	Habit, brand attitude (Tropicana preference), operant conditioning	Location proximity, store availability, no external influence
Rishabh Sharma	Category A	Urgency/physiological need, zero deliberation, situational motivation	None, purely individual emergency decision
Shobhit Singh Tomar	Category B	Functional attitude, quality perception (colour/pixel), rational evaluation	Family (wife as co-decider), store staff, online reviews
Brijendra Singh Tomar	Category B	Brand trust, perceived reliability, risk-reduction motivation	Family, close relatives as opinion leaders and word-of-mouth sources
Jay Kishan Singh	Category C	Long-term aspiration, self-concept (professional identity), intrinsic motivation	Developer peer group as opinion leaders, family for validation
Shivani Singh	Category C	Camera quality perception, product-specific attitude, functional motivation	Family member as primary reference, in-store comparison influenced final choice

6.1 Internal Factors

Across the six interviews, three dominant internal factor themes emerged. The first is habit and routine, which characterised the Category A purchases almost exclusively. Saurabh's Tropicana purchase is driven by a well-established habit loop, consistent purchase from the same store, reinforced by repeated satisfaction, with only minimal brand-level evaluation. This pattern is entirely consistent with Skinner's operant conditioning framework as applied to consumer behaviour: positive reinforcement (the satisfying taste of Tropicana) strengthens the purchase response, gradually reducing deliberation to near-zero over time (Schiffman et al., 2019). Rishabh's purchase, while also in Category A, bypasses even the habit mechanism, here, the internal driver is a raw physiological need, which in Maslow's (1943) hierarchy represents the most basic and urgent category of human motivation. When physiological needs are triggered in a constrained environment, purchasing behaviour becomes almost reflex-like.

The second internal theme is functional attitude, which dominated the Category B decisions. Both Shobhit and Brijendra were guided by a cognitive evaluation of product attributes, colour and pixel quality in Shobhit's case, brand reliability and after-sales service in Brijendra's. The Tri-Component Attitude Model (Schiffman et al., 2019) maps this well: the cognitive component (belief about product performance) and the affective component (positive feeling toward the Sony or Whirlpool brand) jointly produced the conative component (the purchase act). Notably, the affective component in Brijendra's case was derived not from direct product interaction but from the collective positive emotional experience of his social network, trust by proxy, rather than trust by experience.

The third theme is aspirational self-concept, which characterised the Category C decisions. Both Jay Kishan and Shivani made high-investment purchases directed at products they had wanted for an extended period, three to four years in Jay Kishan's case and six months in Shivani's. Sirgy's (1982) Self-Concept Theory is applicable to both, albeit in different ways. Jay Kishan's MacBook purchase aligns with his professional identity, a developer who owns the tools that the best developers in his peer group use. The purchase is an act of self-congruence: he is buying the product that matches who he believes himself to be professionally. Shivani's camera-driven decision is more product-performance focused, but the sustained desire, the patience to wait for the right model, and the emotional satisfaction of ownership are all hallmarks of an identity-adjacent purchase even when not consciously acknowledged.

6.2 External Factors

External influences showed a clear gradient across the three categories, minimal in Category A, moderate and family-centred in Category B, and indirect but professionally significant in Category C. In Category A, neither respondent cited any external social influence on their purchase. This is consistent with the low-stakes nature of these purchases, the social cost of making a 'wrong' choice is negligible, which removes the motivation to seek external validation.

In Category B, the family unit emerged as the dominant external force. Shobhit's wife participated actively in the decision process, reflecting the growing trend of joint spousal decision-making in Indian middle-class households for significant domestic purchases. Brijendra's case demonstrates a different but equally powerful form of family influence, the collective endorsement of trusted relatives served as both an information source and a risk-reduction mechanism. This is informational social influence in its most classically Indian form: the joint family network functioning as a distributed research and validation system.

In Category C, external influence was present but indirect. Jay Kishan's developer peers influenced him not through social pressure or normative conformity, but through credible, first-hand product testimony, a distinction that Solomon (2020) identifies as the difference between normative and informational reference group influence. Shivani's family member performed a similar function, she did not tell Shivani to buy the Vivo X200, but her photographs demonstrated the product's capabilities more persuasively than any advertisement could. Both cases illustrate opinion leadership in action: influential individuals within a consumer's network shaping decisions through authentic lived experience rather than formal endorsement.

7. Comparative Analysis Across Categories

The table below provides a structured comparative analysis of the decision-making process across the three categories, mapped against the five-stage consumer decision model (Mothersbaugh et al., 2020) and supplementary dimensions drawn from the CBI course frameworks.

Decision Stage	Category A (Under INR 200)	Category B (Utilitarian, INR 10,000+)	Category C (Identity, INR 10,000+)
Problem Recognition	Physiological/situational trigger; spontaneous or urgency-driven	Functional gap, new household need requiring immediate solution	Aspirational desire, long-held goal or specification-driven want
Information Search	None to minimal; relies on memory, habit, and past experience	Extensive, 1 week to 2+ months; online reviews, store visits, word-of-mouth	Targeted, brand pre-decided; research focused on model selection within chosen brand
Evaluation of Alternatives	Very limited; 2 brands at most (Tropicana vs Real); zero deliberation in emergency	Multi-brand comparison across 3–4 options (Sony, LG, Samsung; Whirlpool vs others)	Brand-locked evaluation; competitors compared but rejected on price, OS, or specs
Purchase Decision	Immediate, at nearest available point of sale	Deliberate; timed with price comparison between online and offline channels	Delayed (waited up to 6 months); purchase triggered by financial readiness or model launch
Post-Purchase Behaviour	Satisfaction assumed; no active evaluation; repeat purchase confirms prior choice	High confidence; validated through use over time; no cognitive dissonance	Pride and sense of personal achievement; no public sharing; satisfaction sustained over time
Level of Involvement	Very Low	High	Very High (Functional + Emotional)
Primary Decision Driver	Habit, convenience, proximity, or urgent situational need	Functional performance, brand reliability, price-value ratio, peer recommendations	Product specifications, aspiration, family reference group influence
Reference Group Influence	Negligible, entirely individual decision	Moderate, family co-decision; word-of-mouth from trusted relatives	Indirect but significant, developer peers, family member who owned same product
Channel of Purchase	Nearest available physical outlet	Mixed: physical trial then online purchase for better price	In-store purchase after extensive physical comparison
Information Sources	Memory and past experience only	Online reviews, YouTube, physical store demo, word-of-mouth	Peer feedback, in-store hands-on testing, prior experience with brand ecosystem

Several cross-category patterns are worth highlighting. First, the depth of information search scales almost perfectly with price and involvement, from zero in Rishabh's emergency purchase

to two months of multi-channel research in Shobhit's case. This confirms the theoretical prediction of the ELM model that higher motivation, ability, and opportunity to process information produces more central route processing and more systematic evaluation (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986). Second, the role of the reference group escalates from negligible in Category A to structurally embedded in Category B (family as co-decision-maker) to professionally influential in Category C. Third, post-purchase behaviour reveals an interesting pattern: Category A consumers do not formally evaluate their purchase; satisfaction is simply assumed through continued purchase. Category B consumers actively validate their decision through use over time, Shobhit's year of testing his Sony TV across movies, games, and streaming is a clear example. Category C consumers experience satisfaction as ongoing emotional confirmation, every photograph Shivani takes with her Vivo reinforces the purchase; every time Jay Kishan boots his MacBook, the years of saving feel worthwhile.

8. Marketing Implications

The findings of this study carry concrete implications for marketing managers operating across each of the three product categories. The table below summarises strategic recommendations across five key marketing levers.

Lever	Category A Strategy	Category B Strategy	Category C Strategy
Distribution	Maximum outlet density; ensure product is available at every possible purchase point	Strong omnichannel presence; ensure both physical trial and competitive online pricing	Premium retail environment; experience-led stores; launch events
Communication	Sensory consistency; packaging must trigger automatic recognition at shelf	Content marketing; detailed spec comparisons; video reviews; expert endorsements	Aspirational storytelling; peer testimonials; community-building around product identity
Pricing	Price anchoring; avoid frequent price changes that disrupt habit loop	EMI options, seasonal offers, price-match guarantees to reduce hesitation	Premium pricing signals quality; avoid deep discounting which erodes identity value
Post-Purchase	Low investment needed; ensure product availability for next purchase	Robust after-sales service; warranty communication reduces cognitive dissonance	Unboxing experience; loyalty programs; invite customers into brand community
Reference Groups	Not applicable, decision is individual	Leverage family influencers and satisfied-customer testimonials	Target opinion leaders in professional/aspirational peer groups; developer or creator communities

For Category A brands, the findings reinforce a fundamental strategic truth: the habit loop is both the greatest asset and the greatest vulnerability. Brands like Tropicana that have established habitual purchase patterns must invest relentlessly in maintaining the sensory consistency and retail availability that anchor the habit. Any disruption, a price increase, a packaging change, a stock-out, risks breaking the conditioning and creating an opening for competitors. The Rishabh case adds an important distribution dimension: emergency or impulse Category A purchases are won entirely through placement. A brand absent from transient, high-footfall locations such as railway stations and bus terminals simply does not exist for this consumer segment at the moment of need.

For Category B brands, the Shobhit and Brijendra cases collectively make the case for a dual-channel strategy that acknowledges the hybrid nature of Indian high-involvement purchasing: physical experience first, online price-optimisation second. Brands that make it easy for consumers to touch, see, and test a product in store, while simultaneously offering the best online price, will capture both the sensory validation need and the value-seeking behaviour that

characterises this segment. The Brijendra case also underscores the untapped potential of word-of-mouth marketing programmes, structured referral incentives for existing satisfied customers could dramatically accelerate the information-to-purchase journey for new buyers, particularly in markets where digital review platforms are less trusted than personal networks.

For Category C brands, the key insight from both Jay Kishan and Shivani is that identity-driven consumers are often reluctant to acknowledge the identity dimension of their purchase, yet this dimension is precisely what sustains their loyalty and advocacy. Marketing communications that speak to professional aspiration, craft, and long-term value, rather than overt status signalling, will resonate more authentically with this consumer profile. Apple's consistent positioning of the MacBook as a 'tool for creators' rather than a luxury product is a masterclass in this approach. Similarly, Vivo's Zeiss lens partnership is effective because it grounds a prestige specification in a credible functional narrative, serious photography, not social performance.

9. Conclusion

This study set out to understand consumer decision-making across three purchase categories through the medium of real depth interviews, and the findings exceeded initial expectations in both depth and nuance. The six conversations documented in this report are not simply purchase narratives, they are windows into the psychological, social, and cultural architecture that determines how Indian consumers navigate the marketplace.

Category A purchases revealed that consumer decision-making at the low-price end is far from mindless. It is either the product of sophisticated conditioning built up over months of repetition, or a lightning-fast situational response to an urgent need. Neither involves deliberation in the traditional sense, yet both produce decisive, confident purchasing behaviour. For marketers, this means that the battle for Category A consumers is won not in the advertising campaign but in the store shelf, the street corner, and the railway platform.

Category B purchases demonstrated that Indian middle-class consumers are discerning, patient, and increasingly sophisticated in their use of multiple information channels. They want the tactile assurance of an in-store experience and the financial intelligence of an online comparison. They consult their families, they trust their relatives, and they take their time. Brands that respect and support this process, rather than rushing or manipulating it, earn durable loyalty.

Category C purchases challenged perhaps the most fundamental assumption of the category: that identity products are bought for how they make consumers look. The evidence from this study suggests that Indian consumers in this segment are more likely to justify identity purchases through functional narratives, even when the aspirational dimension is plainly visible to an outside observer. This gap between stated and actual motivation is not a problem to be solved, it is a nuance to be honoured. Marketing communications that validate both the functional and the emotional dimensions of these purchases, without forcing the consumer to choose between them, will strike the most resonant chord.

In summary, this project has reinforced the core insight that underpins the entire discipline of consumer behaviour: people do not simply buy products. They buy solutions to problems, expressions of identity, validations of their place in a social world, and confirmations of the kind of person they believe themselves to be. Understanding this, deeply, empathetically, and without simplification, is the foundation of effective marketing.

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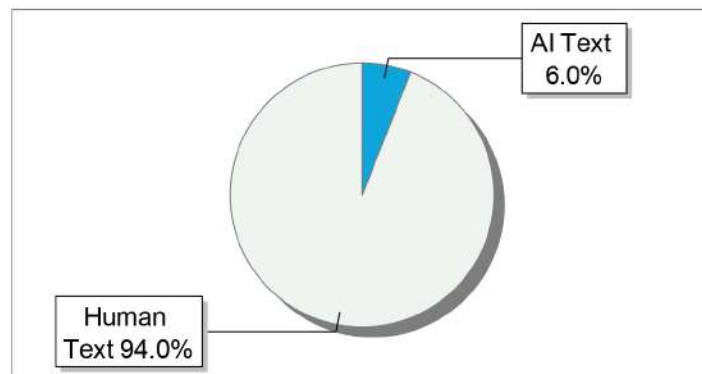
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Introduction Consumer behaviour, at its core, is about understanding why people do what they do when they spend money.

That question sounds deceptively simple, but as this project taught us, the reality is far more layered.

This report is the outcome of Group Project A03 for the Consumer Behaviour Insights course, where our team set out to examine how real people make purchase decisions across three very different types of products.

We structured our research around three categories.

The first Category A covers everyday, low-cost purchases under INR 200: the kind of thing you buy almost without thinking.

The second Category B covers high-value purchases above INR 10,000 made primarily because you need them to function, not because they say something about you.

The third Category C, which covers high-value purchases above INR 10,000 where the product itself becomes a statement, a reflection of who the buyer is or who they want to become.

These three categories were not chosen arbitrarily.

Together, they represent the full range of how involved a consumer gets in a decision, from grabbing a juice at a mart without a second thought, to spending months researching a television, to saving up for years to buy the one laptop you have always wanted.

To gather our data, we conducted six telephonic depth interviews, two per category, with people outside our course who had recently made a qualifying purchase.

What we found surprised us in some ways and confirmed established theory in others.

Not every high-value purchase is driven by identity.

Not every low-value purchase is mindless.

And the role of family, peers, and social networks in shaping what Indian consumers buy is more powerful than any advertisement.

The goal of this report is not simply to describe what six people bought.

It is to decode why, and to translate those findings into something a marketing manager can actually use.

Page 4 2.

Methodology For this project, we chose to go with qualitative research, specifically telephonic depth interviews. The reason was straightforward.

When the goal is to understand why someone bought something, a survey with tick boxes simply does not get you there.

You need a conversation.

You need to be able to ask a follow-up when someone says something interesting, or slow down when they mention something they had not planned to say.

That is what depth interviews allow, and that is why Schiffman, Wisenblit and Kumar (2019) position them as one of the most valuable tools available for uncovering the real drivers behind consumer decisions.

We conducted six interviews in total, two for each of the three product categories.

All six respondents were people outside our course who had made a relevant purchase within the last three months.

The interviews were done over phone calls, each lasting roughly ten to fifteen minutes.

We used a semi-structured format, which means we had a prepared set of questions to keep things consistent across all six conversations, but we also gave ourselves the freedom to dig deeper whenever a respondent said something unexpected or particularly revealing.

Some of the most useful insights from this study came from those unplanned moments.

Our respondents came from our personal and professional networks.

We were conscious about not interviewing the same type of person six times, so we made sure there was a reasonable spread in terms of age, occupation, and life situation.

Every interview was conducted with the respondent's awareness and consent, and we transcribed the responses as soon as each call ended to ensure accuracy.

The questions we asked were built around the assignment brief, but we added our own probing questions wherever we felt the standard list would not surface the full picture.

Our overall framework was the five-stage consumer decision model described by Mothersbaugh, Hawkins and Kleiser (2020), which covers problem recognition, information search, evaluation of alternatives, the purchase itself, and post-purchase behaviour.

Once all six interviews were done, we analysed them in two ways.

First, we looked at each interview on its own to identify what internal and external factors were driving that specific consumer.

Second, we looked across all three categories to find patterns, contrasts, and insights that no single interview could reveal on its own.

Page 5 3.

Individual Interview Summaries, Category A Category A covers low-involvement, routine purchases under INR 200.

Consumer behaviour theory suggests that decisions in this category are characterised by habitual problem-solving or, in some cases, immediate situational responses, with minimal cognitive effort devoted to information search or evaluation of alternatives (Mothersbaugh et al., 2020).

The two respondents in this category presented a particularly interesting contrast one a highly habitual buyer and the other a purely situational, emergency purchaser.

3.1 Interview 1, Saurabh Singh Tomar

Field Details Respondent Saurabh Singh Tomar Product Tropicana Juice (1 litre) Price INR 160–165 Category Category A, Mundane Product Decision Type Habitual / Routine Purchase Key Driver Brand preference + store proximity Saurabh's purchase of Tropicana juice offers a textbook illustration of habitual buying behaviour, which consumer behaviour scholars link directly to operant conditioning.

Having repeatedly purchased Tropicana and experienced consistent satisfaction, Saurabh has been reinforced to select the same product without fresh deliberation a pattern Schiffman et al.

(2019) describe as a conditioned response developed through positive reinforcement over time.

What makes this case particularly interesting is that Saurabh does engage in a minimal degree of evaluation he consciously compares Tropicana and Real Juice yet almost always arrives at the same conclusion.

This reflects what Solomon (2020) terms an 'inertia' purchase pattern, where the appearance of choice masks what is functionally a habitual decision.

The role of the store is equally significant.

Saurabh explicitly states that the purchase is largely location-triggered, passing the mart prompts the purchase rather than a pre-planned need.

This insight has direct implications for point-of-purchase strategy: for Category A brands, shelf visibility and

store proximity function as the primary 'triggers' in the problem recognition stage. The consumer does not arrive with a felt need; the environment creates the need. Maslow's hierarchy is relevant here, the purchase addresses a physiological need (hydration), which means once triggered, motivation to buy is immediate and requires no further persuasion.

Page 6 Internal Factors: Habitual attitude, brand preference (Tropicana over Real), positive reinforcement through repeated satisfaction, physiological motivation.

External Factors: Store proximity and location serve as environmental triggers; no social influence identified.

3.2 Interview 2, Rishabh Sharma

Field Details Respondent Rishabh Sharma Product Slippers Price INR 200 Category Category A, Mundane Product Decision Type Emergency / Situational Purchase Key Driver Urgent need + nearest available outlet Rishabh's purchase of slippers at a railway station presents a sharply contrasting case to Saurabh's habitual buying.

Here, the decision was not driven by habit or brand preference but by an acute situational need, he was wearing shoes on a train journey and required slippers before boarding.

The decision-making process was compressed entirely into a single moment: problem recognition and purchase occurred almost simultaneously, with no information search, no evaluation of alternatives, and no brand consideration whatsoever.

He picked up the first available pair from the nearest stall.

This behaviour is consistent with what Mothersbaugh et al.

(2020) call 'nominal decision-making' or 'routine problem-solving,' where low involvement and high urgency combine to eliminate deliberation entirely.

The Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM) is instructive here, in situations of high situational pressure and low motivation to process information, consumers default to peripheral cues such as physical availability rather than central evaluation of product attributes (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986).

Rishabh did not consider whether the slippers were of good quality or whether another stall might offer a better option, proximity was the only criterion.

The contrast with Saurabh is analytically important.

Both are Category A purchases, yet the psychological processes are entirely different.

Saurabh's purchase is driven by a conditioned habit loop; Rishabh's is driven by an acute situational trigger.

For marketers, this distinction Page 7 matters: Saurabh can be retained through consistency and availability, while a Rishabh-type consumer can be captured purely through strategic placement at high-traffic transient locations.

Internal Factors: Urgent physiological need, zero deliberation, no brand attitude involved.

External Factors: None, purely individual situational decision driven by physical location.

Page 8 4.

Individual Interview Summaries, Category B Category B captures high-involvement utilitarian purchases above INR 10,000.

Unlike Category A, consumers in this segment engage in what Mothersbaugh et al.

(2020) term 'extended problem-solving,' involving deliberate and often extensive information search, systematic evaluation of multiple alternatives, and careful consideration of post-purchase factors such as warranty and service support.

Both respondents in this category demonstrated this pattern, though the nature and channels of their information search differed meaningfully.

4.1 Interview 3, Shobhit Singh Tomar

Field Details Respondent Shobhit Singh Tomar Product Sony Bravia 2 Series LED Television Price INR 58,000 (MRP INR 62,000) Category Category B, Utilitarian Product Decision Type Extended Problem-Solving / High Involvement Key Driver Picture quality + value-for-money + joint family decision Shobhit's purchase of a Sony

Bravia television is one of the most comprehensively documented decision processes in this study.

As a newly married individual setting up a new home, the purchase of a television represented a considered household investment.

The problem recognition was deliberate, the absence of a television in the new home created a felt need, and the subsequent decision process spanned over two months, encompassing online research, physical store visits to Croma and Sony showrooms, and a direct comparison between Sony Bravia 2, Sony Bravia 3, LG, and Samsung models.

The Tri-Component Attitude Model (Schiffman et al., 2019) is highly applicable here.

Shobhit's cognitive component was strong, he evaluated multiple brands on technical attributes including colour accuracy, pixel quality, and screen type.

His affective component was grounded in the tangible experience of viewing the products in-store, where the Sony's picture quality made a superior impression.

The conative component manifested in the final purchase act, notably executed on Amazon after confirming that the price was lower than in-store.

This hybrid channel behaviour, physical evaluation followed by online purchase, is a growing pattern in Indian consumer behaviour and presents a significant challenge for brick-and-mortar retailers.

Page 9 The role of Shobhit's wife as a co-decider is also noteworthy.

This reflects a shift in Indian household decision-making patterns, where high-value domestic purchases are increasingly joint decisions rather than being driven by a single family member.

Over one year after the purchase, Shobhit reports complete satisfaction and no cognitive dissonance, a strong indicator that the extended deliberation process served its risk-reduction function effectively.

Internal Factors: Functional attitude toward Sony brand, quality perception, rational multi-attribute evaluation, value-consciousness.

External Factors: Wife as co-decider, in-store product demonstration, online price comparison served as information sources.

4.2 Interview 4, Brijendra Singh Tomar

Field Details Respondent Brijendra Singh Tomar Product Whirlpool Fully Automatic Washing Machine Price INR 25,000 Category Category B, Utilitarian Product Decision Type Extended Problem-Solving / Word-of-Mouth Driven Key Driver Brand reputation + trusted personal recommendations Brijendra's purchase of a Whirlpool washing machine provides a fascinating study in the power of personal reference groups as information sources, particularly in the context of Indian family structures.

The decision emerged from a newly felt household need, the family had been managing without an automatic washing machine, but increasing domestic workload made it a practical necessity.

Unlike Shobhit, who relied heavily on digital research and store visits, Brijendra's information search was almost entirely interpersonal, anchored in conversations with close relatives who already owned Whirlpool machines.

This behaviour aligns closely with Reference Group Theory as outlined by Schiffman et al.

(2019), where informational social influence, seeking guidance from credible personal sources, plays a dominant role in high-involvement purchase decisions.

The fact that multiple trusted people in Brijendra's circle endorsed the same brand removed the need for comparative evaluation almost entirely.

Whirlpool's consistent positive word-of-mouth effectively pre-empted the alternative evaluation stage of the decision process.

This is a powerful illustration of Page 10 how opinion leadership within a social network can compress what might otherwise be a lengthy decision into a relatively quick one.

The channel choice, local store rather than online, was determined not by preference but by product availability, as the specific model was not listed on any e-commerce platform at the time of purchase.

This is a distribution insight that Whirlpool and similar brands must take seriously: in semi-urban and smaller city markets, offline availability remains a decisive purchase driver, and gaps in online inventory can cede ground to competing brands.

Post-purchase confidence was high, consistent with the reassurance derived from trusted social endorsement. Internal Factors: Brand trust, perceived reliability, risk-reduction motivation, practical utility focus. External Factors: Family and close relatives as primary opinion leaders, word-of-mouth as dominant information channel.

Page 11 5.

Individual Interview Summaries, Category C Category C covers purchases above INR 10,000 that consumers associate with personal identity or self-expression.

Consumer behaviour theory, particularly Sirgy's (1982) Self-Concept Theory, proposes that consumers choose products whose perceived image is congruent with their actual or aspirational self-concept.

Both respondents in this category made high-value purchases, yet interestingly, neither framed their decision in explicitly identity-driven terms, a finding that deserves careful analytical attention.

5.1 Interview 5 , Jay Kishan Singh

Field Details Respondent Jay Kishan Singh Product Apple MacBook Pro Price INR 1,80,000 Category Category C, Identity Product Decision Type Aspirational / Long-Term Planned Purchase Key Driver Functional aspiration + professional peer influence + financial readiness Jay Kishan's purchase of an Apple MacBook Pro at INR 1.8 lakh is perhaps the most analytically rich case in this study, precisely because it challenges the expected framing of Category C purchases.

When asked whether the purchase was motivated by how others would perceive him, Jay Kishan explicitly and emphatically denied a status-driven motivation.

He described it as 'a good investment, not a status symbol,' grounded in the technical superiority of macOS, battery life, processing speed, and the Apple ecosystem.

Yet the very features he cited, premium pricing, brand exclusivity, and professional peer ownership, are the markers that consumer behaviour theory identifies as identity-signalling attributes (Solomon, 2020).

This tension between stated functional motivation and implicit identity signalling is a recurring and well-documented phenomenon in consumer psychology.

Consumers frequently rationalise identity-driven purchases in functional terms as a means of resolving the cognitive dissonance between self-perception as a rational buyer and the emotional reality of aspirational consumption.

Jay Kishan saved money specifically for this purchase over three to four years, a level of sustained financial commitment that goes far beyond what a purely utilitarian purchase would warrant.

The fact that he showed the MacBook to his family as a 'personal achievement' Page 12 further confirms the symbolic, identity-affirming dimension of the purchase, even if he does not consciously categorise it as such.

The influence of his developer peer group is also a classic example of informational reference group influence, where credibility of the source, not merely the social desire to conform, drives the decision.

This aligns with Schiffman et al.'s (2019) distinction between informational and normative social influence, suggesting that Jay Kishan's decision sits at the intersection of rational evaluation and aspirational identity, making him a particularly nuanced consumer profile.

Internal Factors: Long-term aspiration, professional self-concept, intrinsic motivation (achievement), functional product attitude.

External Factors: Developer peer group as credible opinion leaders, family as validation reference group.

5.2 Interview 6, Shivani Singh

Field Details Respondent Shivani Singh Product Vivo X200 Smartphone Price INR 65,000 Category Category C, Identity Product Decision Type Specification-Driven / Patiently Planned Purchase Key Driver Camera capability + family reference + in-store comparative testing Shivani's purchase of the Vivo X200 at INR 65,000 in December 2025 presents a different dimension of Category C consumer behaviour.

Like Jay Kishan, she denied that external perception drove her decision, stating it was 'purely for me.' Yet her decision process was deeply shaped by a family member who already owned the same product, whose

photography output she had personally observed and been impressed by.

This is a textbook example of what Schiffman et al.

(2019) call 'primary reference group influence', where close family members, rather than aspirational figures or celebrities, serve as the most trusted source of product information.

Page 13 What distinguishes Shivani's decision is the remarkable patience demonstrated in her purchase timeline. Upon learning that a new model was forthcoming, she waited six months rather than purchasing the existing version, a decision that reflects high product involvement and what consumer researchers describe as 'anticipatory socialisation,' where consumers defer gratification in order to acquire the ideal version of a desired product.

This level of planning and patience is rarely seen in Category A purchases and even in some Category B decisions, underscoring the unique psychological depth of identity-category purchases.

Her in-store research methodology was also notably rigorous, she physically tested and photographed subjects using iPhone, Samsung, OnePlus, and Vivo X200 side by side, ultimately selecting the product that delivered the best photographic output in her own hands-on evaluation.

The iPhone was dismissed not on capability grounds but on price and operating system preference, reflecting a pragmatic, specification-led evaluation overlay on what remains, at its core, an identity-adjacent purchase.

Her continued satisfaction, every photograph she takes reinforces the purchase decision, illustrates sustained post-purchase consonance driven by daily functional confirmation of the original choice.

Internal Factors: Camera quality perception, product-specific functional attitude, patience and delayed gratification, Android ecosystem preference.

External Factors: Family member as primary reference group, in-store physical demonstration as key evaluation tool.

Page 14 6.

Thematic Analysis: Internal and External Factors A cross-category analysis of all six interviews reveals a rich landscape of internal and external influences that shape consumer decisions at each price and involvement level. Rather than operating in isolation, these factors interact, sometimes reinforcing each other, sometimes creating tension, producing the complex, contextually embedded decision processes documented in this study.

The table below provides a consolidated view of the key internal and external factors identified across all six respondents.

Respondent	Category	Internal Factors	External Factors
Saurabh Singh Tomar	Category A	Habit, brand attitude (Tropicana preference), operant conditioning	Location proximity, store availability, no external influence
Rishabh Sharma	Category A	Urgency/physiological need, zero deliberation, situational motivation	None, purely individual emergency decision
Shobhit Singh Tomar	Category B	Functional attitude, quality perception (colour/pixel), rational evaluation	Family (wife as co-decider), store staff, online reviews
Brijendra Singh Tomar	Category B	Brand trust, perceived reliability, risk-reduction motivation	Family, close relatives as opinion leaders and word-of-mouth sources
Jay Kishan Singh	Category C	Long-term aspiration, self-concept (professional identity), intrinsic motivation	Developer peer group as opinion leaders, family for validation
Shivani Singh	Category C	Camera quality perception, product-specific attitude, functional motivation	Family member as primary reference, in-store comparison influenced final choice

6.1 Internal Factors

Across the six interviews, three dominant internal factor themes emerged.

The first is habit and routine, which characterised the Category A purchases almost exclusively.

Saurabh's Tropicana purchase is driven by a well-established habit loop, consistent purchase from the same store, reinforced by repeated satisfaction, with only minimal brand-level evaluation.

This pattern is entirely consistent with Skinner's operant conditioning framework as applied to consumer behaviour: positive reinforcement (the satisfying taste of Tropicana) strengthens the purchase response, gradually reducing deliberation to near-zero over time (Schiffman et al., 2019).

Rishabh's purchase, while also in Category A, bypasses even the habit mechanism, here, the internal driver is a raw physiological need, which in Maslow's (1943) hierarchy represents the most basic and urgent category of human motivation.

When physiological needs are triggered in a constrained environment, purchasing behaviour becomes almost reflex-like.

Page 15 The second internal theme is functional attitude, which dominated the Category B decisions.

Both Shobhit and Brijendra were guided by a cognitive evaluation of product attributes, colour and pixel quality in Shobhit's case, brand reliability and after-sales service in Brijendra's.

The Tri-Component Attitude Model (Schiffman et al., 2019) maps this well: the cognitive component (belief about product performance) and the affective component (positive feeling toward the Sony or Whirlpool brand) jointly produced the conative component (the purchase act).

Notably, the affective component in Brijendra's case was derived not from direct product interaction but from the collective positive emotional experience of his social network, trust by proxy, rather than trust by experience.

The third theme is aspirational self-concept, which characterised the Category C decisions.

Both Jay Kishan and Shivani made high-investment purchases directed at products they had wanted for an extended period, three to four years in Jay Kishan's case and six months in Shivani's.

Sirgy's (1982) Self-Concept Theory is applicable to both, albeit in different ways.

Jay Kishan's MacBook purchase aligns with his professional identity, a developer who owns the tools that the best developers in his peer group use.

The purchase is an act of self-congruence: he is buying the product that matches who he believes himself to be professionally.

Shivani's camera-driven decision is more product-performance focused, but the sustained desire, the patience to wait for the right model, and the emotional satisfaction of ownership are all hallmarks of an identity- adjacent purchase even when not consciously acknowledged.

6.2 External Factors

External influences showed a clear gradient across the three categories, minimal in Category A, moderate and family-centred in Category B, and indirect but professionally significant in Category C.

In Category A, neither respondent cited any external social influence on their purchase.

This is consistent with the low-stakes nature of these purchases, the social cost of making a 'wrong' choice is negligible, which removes the motivation to seek external validation.

In Category B, the family unit emerged as the dominant external force.

Shobhit's wife participated actively in the decision process, reflecting the growing trend of joint spousal decision-making in Indian middle-class households for significant domestic purchases.

Brijendra's case demonstrates a different but equally powerful form of family influence, the collective endorsement of trusted relatives served as both an information source and a risk- reduction mechanism.

This is informational social influence in its most classically Indian form: the joint family network functioning as a distributed research and validation system.

Page 16 In Category C, external influence was present but indirect.

Jay Kishan's developer peers influenced him not through social pressure or normative conformity, but through credible, first- hand product testimony, a distinction that Solomon (2020) identifies as the difference between normative and informational reference group influence.

Shivani's family member performed a similar function, she did not tell Shivani to buy the Vivo X200, but her photographs demonstrated the product's capabilities more persuasively than any advertisement could.

Both cases illustrate opinion leadership in action: influential individuals within a consumer's network shaping decisions through authentic lived experience rather than formal endorsement.

Page 17 7.

Comparative Analysis Across Categories The table below provides a structured comparative analysis of the decision-making process across the three categories, mapped against the five-stage consumer decision model (Mothersbaugh et al., 2020) and supplementary dimensions drawn from the CBI course frameworks.

Reference Group

Influence Negligible, entirely

individual decision
Moderate, family co-
decision; word-of-mouth
from trusted relatives
Indirect but significant,
developer peers, family
member who owned same
product
Channel of
Purchase Nearest available physical outlet
Mixed: physical trial then
online purchase for better
price
In-store purchase after
extensive physical
comparison
Information
Sources Memory and past
experience only
Online reviews, YouTube,
physical store demo,
word-of-mouth
Peer feedback, in-store
hands-on testing, prior
experience with brand
ecosystem

Several cross-category patterns are worth highlighting. First, the depth of information search scales almost perfectly with price and involvement, from zero in Rishabh's emergency purchase
Page 18

to two months of multi-channel research in Shobhit's case. This confirms the theoretical prediction of the ELM model that higher motivation, ability, and opportunity to process information produces more central route processing and more systematic evaluation (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986). Second, the role of the reference group escalates from negligible in Category A to structurally embedded in Category B (family as co-decision-maker) to professionally influential in Category C. Third, post-purchase behaviour reveals an interesting pattern: Category A consumers do not formally evaluate their purchase; satisfaction is simply assumed through continued purchase. Category B consumers actively validate their decision through use over time, Shobhit's year of testing his Sony TV across movies, games, and streaming is a clear example. Category C consumers experience satisfaction as ongoing emotional confirmation, every photograph Shivani takes with her Vivo reinforces the purchase; every time Jay Kishan boots his MacBook, the years of saving feel worthwhile.

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8. Marketing Implications

The findings of this study carry concrete implications for marketing managers operating across each of the three product categories. The table below summarises strategic recommendations across five key marketing levers.

Lever	Category A Strategy	Category B Strategy	Category C Strategy
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Distribution	Maximum outlet density;		
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	ensure product is available at every possible purchase point		
--	--	--	--

	Strong omnichannel		
--	--------------------	--	--

presence; ensure both
physical trial and
competitive online pricing
Premium retail
environment; experience-
led stores; launch events
Communication Sensory consistency;
packaging must trigger
automatic recognition at
shelf
Content marketing;
detailed spec comparisons;
video reviews; expert
endorsements
Aspirational storytelling;
peer testimonials;
community-building around
product identity
Pricing Price anchoring; avoid
frequent price changes that
disrupt habit loop
EMI options, seasonal
offers, price-match
guarantees to reduce
hesitation
Premium pricing signals
quality; avoid deep
discounting which erodes
identity value
Post-Purchase Low investment needed;
ensure product availability
for next purchase
Robust after-sales service;
warranty communication
reduces cognitive
dissonance
Unboxing experience;
loyalty programs; invite
customers into brand
community
Reference
Groups Not applicable, decision is
individual
Leverage family
influencers and satisfied-
customer testimonials
Target opinion leaders in
professional/aspirational
peer groups; developer or
creator communities

For Category A brands, the findings reinforce a fundamental strategic truth: the habit loop is both the greatest asset and the greatest vulnerability. Brands like Tropicana that have established

habitual purchase patterns must invest relentlessly in maintaining the sensory consistency and retail availability that anchor the habit. Any disruption, a price increase, a packaging change, a stock-out, risks breaking the conditioning and creating an opening for competitors. The Rishabh case adds an important distribution dimension: emergency or impulse Category A purchases are won entirely through placement. A brand absent from transient, high-footfall locations such as railway stations and bus terminals simply does not exist for this consumer segment at the moment of need.

For Category B brands, the Shobhit and Brijendra cases collectively make the case for a dual-channel strategy that acknowledges the hybrid nature of Indian high-involvement purchasing: physical experience first, online price-optimisation second. Brands that make it easy for consumers to touch, see, and test a product in store, while simultaneously offering the best online price, will capture both the sensory validation need and the value-seeking behaviour that

Page 20

characterises this segment. The Brijendra case also underscores the untapped potential of word-of-mouth marketing programmes, structured referral incentives for existing satisfied customers could dramatically accelerate the information-to-purchase journey for new buyers, particularly in markets where digital review platforms are less trusted than personal networks.

For Category C brands, the key insight from both Jay Kishan and Shivani is that identity-driven consumers are often reluctant to acknowledge the identity dimension of their purchase, yet this dimension is precisely what sustains their loyalty and advocacy. Marketing communications that speak to professional aspiration, craft, and long-term value, rather than overt status signalling, will resonate more authentically with this consumer profile. Apple's consistent positioning of the MacBook as a 'tool for creators' rather than a luxury product is a masterclass in this approach. Similarly, Vivo's Zeiss lens partnership is effective because it grounds a prestige specification in a credible functional narrative, serious photography, not social performance.

Page 21

9. Conclusion

This study set out to understand consumer decision-making across three purchase categories through the medium of real depth interviews, and the findings exceeded initial expectations in both depth and nuance. The six conversations documented in this report are not simply purchase narratives, they are windows into the psychological, social, and cultural architecture that determines how Indian consumers navigate the marketplace.

Category A purchases revealed that consumer decision-making at the low-price end is far from mindless. It is either the product of sophisticated conditioning built up over months of repetition, or a lightning-fast situational response to an urgent need. Neither involves deliberation in the traditional sense, yet both produce decisive, confident purchasing behaviour. For marketers, this means that the battle for Category A consumers is won not in the advertising campaign but in the store shelf, the street corner, and the railway platform.

Category B purchases demonstrated that Indian middle-class consumers are discerning, patient, and increasingly sophisticated in their use of multiple information channels. They want the tactile assurance of an in-store experience and the financial intelligence of an online comparison. They consult their families, they trust their relatives, and they take their time. Brands that respect and support this process, rather than rushing or manipulating it, earn durable loyalty.

Category C purchases challenged perhaps the most fundamental assumption of the category: that identity products are bought for how they make consumers look. The evidence from this study suggests that Indian consumers in this segment are more likely to justify identity purchases through functional narratives, even when the aspirational dimension is plainly visible to an outside observer. This gap between stated and actual motivation is not a problem to be solved, it is a nuance to be honoured. Marketing communications that validate both the functional and the emotional dimensions of these purchases, without forcing the consumer to choose between them, will strike the most resonant chord.

In summary, this project has reinforced the core insight that underpins the entire discipline of consumer behaviour: people do not simply buy products. They buy solutions to problems, expressions of identity, validations of their place in a social world, and confirmations of the kind of person they believe themselves to be. Understanding this, deeply, empathetically, and without simplification, is the foundation of effective marketing.

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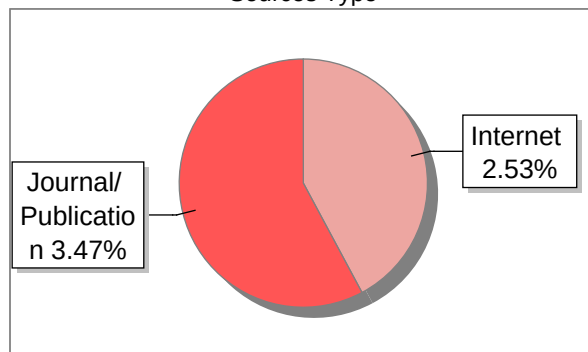
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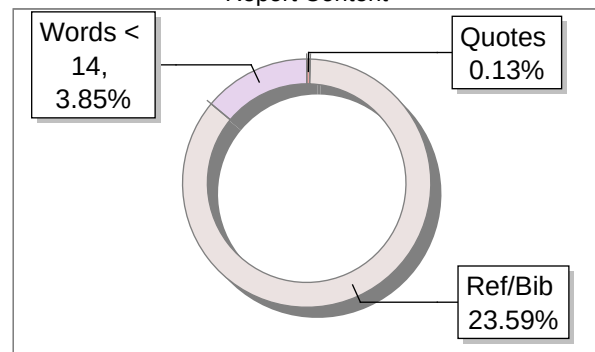
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CONSUMER BEHAVIOUR INSIGHTS

Decoding Consumer Decisions “Qualitative Dive Across Price & Involvement Levels”

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1. Introduction

Consumer behaviour, at its core, is about understanding why people do what they do when they spend money. That question sounds deceptively simple, but as this project taught us, the reality is far more layered. This report is the outcome of Group Project A03 for the Consumer Behaviour Insights course, where our team set out to examine how real people make purchase decisions across three very different types of products.

¹³ We structured our research around three categories. The first Category A covers everyday, low-cost purchases under INR 200: the kind of thing you buy almost without thinking. The second Category B covers high-value purchases above INR 10,000 made primarily because you need them to function, not because they say something about you. ²³ The third Category C, which covers high-value purchases above INR 10,000 where the product itself becomes a statement, a reflection of who the buyer is or who they want to become. ²⁴ These three categories were not chosen arbitrarily.

Together, they represent the full range of how involved a consumer gets in a decision, from grabbing a juice at a mart without a second thought, to spending months researching a television, to saving up for years to buy the one laptop you have always wanted.

To gather our data, we conducted six telephonic depth interviews, two per category, with people outside our course who had recently made a qualifying purchase. What we found surprised us in some ways and confirmed established theory in others. Not every high-value purchase is driven by identity. Not every low-value purchase is mindless.

And the role of family, peers, and social networks in shaping what Indian consumers buy is more powerful than any advertisement.

The goal of this report is not simply to describe what six people bought. It is to decode why, and to translate those findings into something a marketing manager can actually use.

2. Methodology

For this project, we chose to go with qualitative research, specifically telephonic depth interviews. The reason was straightforward. When the goal is to understand why someone bought something, a survey with tick boxes simply does not get you there. You need a conversation. ⁴ You need to be able to ask a follow-up when someone says something interesting, or slow down when they mention ¹⁰ something they had not planned to say. That is what depth interviews allow, and that is why Schiffman, Wisenblit and Kumar (2019) position them as ⁸ one of the most valuable tools available for uncovering the real drivers behind consumer decisions.

We conducted six interviews in total, two for each of the three product categories. All six respondents were people outside our course who had made a relevant purchase within the last three months. The interviews were done over phone calls, each lasting roughly ten to fifteen minutes. We used a semi-structured format, which means we had a prepared set of questions ⁵ to keep things consistent across all six conversations, but we also gave ourselves the freedom to dig deeper whenever a respondent said something unexpected or particularly revealing. Some ¹² of the most useful insights from this study came from those unplanned moments.

Our respondents came from our personal and professional networks. We were conscious about not interviewing the same type of person six times, so we made sure there was a reasonable spread ¹¹ in terms of age, occupation, and life situation. Every interview was conducted with the respondent's awareness and consent, and we transcribed the responses as soon as each call ended to ensure accuracy.

The questions we asked were built around the assignment brief, but we added our own probing questions wherever we felt the standard list would not surface the full picture. Our overall framework was the five-stage consumer decision model described by Mothersbaugh, Hawkins and Kleiser (2020), which covers ¹² problem recognition, information search, evaluation of alternatives, the purchase itself, and post-purchase behaviour. Once all six interviews were done, we analysed them in two ways. First, we looked at each interview on its own to identify what internal and external factors were driving that specific consumer. Second, we looked across all three categories to find patterns, contrasts, and insights that no single interview could reveal on its own.

3. Individual Interview Summaries, Category A

Category A covers low-involvement, routine purchases under INR 200. ²¹ Consumer behaviour theory suggests that decisions in this category are characterised by habitual problem-solving or, in some cases, immediate situational responses, with minimal cognitive effort devoted to information search or evaluation of alternatives (Mothersbaugh et al., 2020). The two respondents in this category presented a particularly interesting contrast one a highly habitual buyer and the other a purely situational, emergency purchaser.

3.1 Interview 1, Saurabh Singh Tomar

Field	Details
Respondent	Saurabh Singh Tomar
Product	Tropicana Juice (1 litre)
Price	INR 160–165
Category	Category A, Mundane Product
Decision Type	Habitual / Routine Purchase
Key Driver	Brand preference + store proximity

Saurabh's purchase of Tropicana juice offers a textbook illustration of habitual buying behaviour, which consumer behaviour scholars link directly to operant conditioning. Having repeatedly purchased Tropicana and experienced consistent satisfaction, Saurabh has been reinforced to select the same product without fresh deliberation a pattern Schiffman et al. (2019) describe as a conditioned response developed through positive reinforcement over time. ⁹ What makes this case particularly interesting is that Saurabh does engage in a minimal degree of evaluation he consciously compares Tropicana and Real Juice yet almost always arrives at the same conclusion. This reflects what Solomon (2020) terms an 'inertia' purchase pattern, where the appearance of choice masks what is functionally a habitual decision.

The role of the store is equally significant. Saurabh explicitly states that the purchase is largely location-triggered, passing the mart prompts the purchase rather than a pre-planned need. ¹⁶ This insight has direct implications for point-of-purchase strategy: for Category A brands, shelf visibility and store proximity function as the primary 'triggers' in the problem recognition stage. The consumer does not arrive with a felt need; the environment creates the need. Maslow's hierarchy is relevant here, the purchase addresses a physiological need (hydration), which means once triggered, motivation to buy is immediate and requires no further persuasion.

Internal Factors: Habitual attitude, brand preference (Tropicana over Real), positive reinforcement through repeated satisfaction, physiological motivation.

External Factors: Store proximity and location serve as environmental triggers; no social influence identified.

3.2 Interview 2, Rishabh Sharma

Field	Details
Respondent	Rishabh Sharma
Product	Slippers
Price	INR 200
Category	Category A, Mundane Product
Decision Type	Emergency / Situational Purchase
Key Driver	Urgent need + nearest available outlet

Rishabh's purchase of slippers at a railway station presents a sharply contrasting case to Saurabh's habitual buying. Here, the decision was not driven by habit or brand preference but by an acute situational need, he was wearing shoes on a train journey and required slippers before boarding. The decision-making process was compressed entirely into a single moment: problem recognition and purchase occurred almost simultaneously, with no information search, no evaluation of alternatives, and no brand consideration whatsoever. He picked up the first available pair from the nearest stall.

This behaviour is consistent with what Mothersbaugh et al. (2020) call 'nominal decision-making' or 'routine problem-solving,' where low involvement and high urgency combine to eliminate deliberation entirely. The Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM) is instructive here, in situations of high situational pressure and low motivation to process information, consumers default to peripheral cues such as physical availability rather than central evaluation of product attributes (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986). Rishabh did not consider whether the slippers were of good quality or whether another stall might offer a better option, proximity was the only criterion.

The contrast with Saurabh is analytically important. Both are Category A purchases, yet the psychological processes are entirely different. Saurabh's purchase is driven by a conditioned habit loop; Rishabh's is driven by an acute situational trigger. For marketers, this distinction

matters: Saurabh can be retained through consistency and availability, while a Rishabh-type consumer can be captured purely through strategic placement at high-traffic transient locations.

Internal Factors: Urgent physiological need, zero deliberation, no brand attitude involved.

External Factors: None, purely individual situational decision driven by physical location.

4. Individual Interview Summaries, Category B

Category B captures high-involvement utilitarian purchases above INR 10,000. Unlike Category A, consumers in this segment engage in what Mothersbaugh et al. (2020) term 'extended problem-solving,' involving deliberate and often extensive information search, systematic evaluation of multiple alternatives, and careful consideration of post-purchase factors such as warranty and service support. Both respondents in this category demonstrated this pattern, though the nature and channels of their information search differed meaningfully.

4.1 Interview 3, Shobhit Singh Tomar

Field	Details
Respondent	Shobhit Singh Tomar
Product	Sony Bravia 2 Series LED Television
Price	INR 58,000 (MRP INR 62,000)
Category	Category B, Utilitarian Product
Decision Type	Extended Problem-Solving / High Involvement
Key Driver	Picture quality + value-for-money + joint family decision

Shobhit's purchase of a Sony Bravia television ⁶ is one of the most comprehensively documented decision processes in this study. As a newly married individual setting up a new home, the purchase of a television represented a considered household investment. The problem recognition was deliberate, the absence of a television in the new home created a felt need, and the subsequent decision process spanned over two months, encompassing online research, physical store visits to Croma and Sony showrooms, and a direct comparison between Sony Bravia 2, Sony Bravia 3, LG, and Samsung models.

The Tri-Component Attitude Model (Schiffman et al., 2019) is highly applicable here. Shobhit's cognitive component was strong, he evaluated multiple brands on technical attributes including colour accuracy, pixel quality, and screen type. His affective component was grounded in the tangible experience of viewing the products in-store, where the Sony's picture quality made a superior impression. The conative component manifested in the final purchase act, notably executed on Amazon after confirming that the price was lower than in-store. This hybrid channel behaviour, physical evaluation followed by online purchase, is a growing pattern in Indian consumer behaviour and presents a significant challenge for brick-and-mortar retailers.

The role of Shobhit's wife as a co-decider is also noteworthy. This reflects a shift in Indian household decision-making patterns, where high-value domestic purchases are increasingly joint decisions rather than being driven by a single family member. Over one year after the purchase, Shobhit reports complete satisfaction and no cognitive dissonance, a strong indicator that the extended deliberation process served its risk-reduction function effectively.

Internal Factors: Functional attitude toward Sony brand, quality perception, rational multi-attribute evaluation, value-consciousness.

External Factors: Wife as co-decider, in-store product demonstration, online price comparison served as information sources.

4.2 Interview 4, Brijendra Singh Tomar

Field	Details
Respondent	Brijendra Singh Tomar
Product	Whirlpool Fully Automatic Washing Machine
Price	INR 25,000
Category	Category B, Utilitarian Product
Decision Type	Extended Problem-Solving / Word-of-Mouth Driven
Key Driver	Brand reputation + trusted personal recommendations

Brijendra's purchase of a Whirlpool washing machine provides a fascinating study in the power of personal reference groups as information sources, particularly in the context of Indian family structures. The decision emerged from a newly felt household need, the family had been managing without an automatic washing machine, but increasing domestic workload made it a practical necessity. Unlike Shobhit, who relied heavily on digital research and store visits, Brijendra's information search was almost entirely interpersonal, anchored in conversations with close relatives who already owned Whirlpool machines.

This behaviour aligns closely with Reference Group Theory as outlined by Schiffman et al. (2019), where informational social influence, seeking guidance from credible personal sources, plays a dominant role in high-involvement purchase decisions. The fact that multiple trusted people in Brijendra's circle endorsed the same brand removed the need for comparative evaluation almost entirely. Whirlpool's consistent positive word-of-mouth effectively preempted the alternative evaluation stage of the decision process. This is a powerful illustration of

how opinion leadership within a social network can compress what might otherwise be a lengthy decision into a relatively quick one.

The channel choice, local store rather than online, was determined not by preference but by product availability, as the specific model was not listed on any e-commerce platform at the time of purchase. This is a distribution insight that Whirlpool and similar brands must take seriously: in semi-urban and smaller city markets, offline availability remains a decisive purchase driver, and gaps in online inventory can cede ground to competing brands. Post-purchase confidence was high, consistent with the reassurance derived from trusted social endorsement.

Internal Factors: Brand trust, perceived reliability, risk-reduction motivation, practical utility focus.

External Factors: Family and close relatives as primary opinion leaders, word-of-mouth as dominant information channel.

5. Individual Interview Summaries, Category C

Category C covers purchases above INR 10,000 that consumers associate with personal identity or self-expression. Consumer behaviour theory, particularly Sirgy's (1982) Self-Concept Theory, proposes that consumers choose products whose perceived image is congruent with their actual or aspirational self-concept. Both respondents in this category made high-value purchases, yet interestingly, neither framed their decision in explicitly identity-driven terms, a finding that deserves careful analytical attention.

5.1 Interview 5 , Jay Kishan Singh

Field	Details
Respondent	Jay Kishan Singh
Product	Apple MacBook Pro
Price	INR 1,80,000
Category	Category C, Identity Product
Decision Type	Aspirational / Long-Term Planned Purchase
Key Driver	Functional aspiration + professional peer influence + financial readiness

Jay Kishan's purchase of an Apple MacBook Pro at INR 1.8 lakh is perhaps the most analytically rich case in this study, precisely because it challenges the expected framing of Category C purchases. When asked whether the purchase was motivated by how others would perceive him, Jay Kishan explicitly and emphatically denied a status-driven motivation. He described it as 'a good investment, not a status symbol,' grounded in the technical superiority of macOS, battery life, processing speed, and the Apple ecosystem. Yet the very features he cited, premium pricing, brand exclusivity, and professional peer ownership, are the markers that consumer behaviour theory identifies as identity-signalling attributes (Solomon, 2020).

This tension between stated functional motivation and implicit identity signalling is a recurring and well-documented phenomenon in consumer psychology. Consumers frequently rationalise identity-driven purchases in functional terms as a means of resolving the cognitive dissonance between self-perception as a rational buyer and the emotional reality of aspirational consumption. Jay Kishan saved money specifically for this purchase over three to four years, a level of sustained financial commitment that goes far beyond what a purely utilitarian purchase would warrant. The fact that he showed the MacBook to his family as a 'personal achievement'

further confirms the symbolic, identity-affirming dimension of the purchase, even if he does not consciously categorise it as such.

The influence of his developer peer group is also a classic example of informational reference group influence, where credibility of the source, not merely the social desire to conform, drives the decision. This aligns with Schiffman et al.'s (2019) distinction between informational and normative social influence, suggesting that Jay Kishan's decision sits at the intersection of rational evaluation and aspirational identity, making him a particularly nuanced consumer profile.

Internal Factors: Long-term aspiration, professional self-concept, intrinsic motivation (achievement), functional product attitude.

External Factors: Developer peer group as credible opinion leaders, family as validation reference group.

5.2 Interview 6, Shivani Singh

Field	Details
Respondent	Shivani Singh
Product	Vivo X200 Smartphone
Price	INR 65,000
Category	Category C, Identity Product
Decision Type	Specification-Driven / Patiently Planned Purchase
Key Driver	Camera capability + family reference + in-store comparative testing

Shivani's purchase of the Vivo X200 at INR 65,000 in December 2025 presents a different dimension of Category C consumer behaviour. Like Jay Kishan, she denied that external perception drove her decision, stating it was 'purely for me.' Yet her decision process was deeply shaped by a family member who already owned the same product, whose photography output she had personally observed and been impressed by. This is a textbook example of what Schiffman et al. (2019) call 'primary reference group influence', where ²⁵ close family members, rather than aspirational figures or celebrities, serve as the most trusted source of product information.

What distinguishes Shivani's decision is the remarkable patience demonstrated in her purchase timeline. Upon learning that a new model was forthcoming, she waited six months rather than purchasing the existing version, a decision that reflects high product involvement and what consumer researchers describe as 'anticipatory socialisation,' where consumers defer gratification ² in order to acquire the ideal version of a desired product. This level of planning and patience is rarely seen in Category A purchases and even in some Category B decisions, underscoring the unique psychological depth of identity-category purchases.

Her in-store research methodology was also notably rigorous, she physically tested and photographed subjects using iPhone, Samsung, OnePlus, and Vivo X200 side by side, ultimately selecting the product that delivered the best photographic output in her own hands-on evaluation. The iPhone was dismissed not on capability grounds but on price and operating system preference, reflecting a pragmatic, specification-led evaluation overlay on what remains, at its core, an identity-adjacent purchase. Her continued satisfaction, every photograph she takes reinforces the purchase decision, illustrates sustained post-purchase consonance driven by daily functional confirmation of the original choice.

Internal Factors: Camera quality perception, product-specific functional attitude, patience and delayed gratification, Android ecosystem preference.

External Factors: Family member as primary reference group, in-store physical demonstration as key evaluation tool.

6. Thematic Analysis: Internal and External Factors

A cross-category analysis of all six interviews reveals a rich landscape of internal and external influences that shape consumer decisions at each price and involvement level. Rather than operating in isolation, these factors **interact, sometimes reinforcing each other,** sometimes creating tension, producing the complex, contextually embedded decision processes documented in this study. The table below provides a consolidated view of the key internal and external factors identified across all six respondents.

Respondent	Category	Internal Factors	External Factors
Saurabh Singh Tomar	Category A	Habit, brand attitude (Tropicana preference), operant conditioning	Location proximity, store availability, no external influence
Rishabh Sharma	Category A	Urgency/physiological need, zero deliberation, situational motivation	None, purely individual emergency decision
Shobhit Singh Tomar	Category B	Functional attitude, quality perception (colour/pixel), rational evaluation	Family (wife as co-decider), store staff, online reviews
Brijendra Singh Tomar	Category B	Brand trust, perceived reliability, risk-reduction motivation	Family, close relatives as opinion leaders and word-of-mouth sources
Jay Kishan Singh	Category C	Long-term aspiration, self-concept (professional identity), intrinsic motivation	Developer peer group as opinion leaders, family for validation
Shivani Singh	Category C	Camera quality perception, product-specific attitude, functional motivation	Family member as primary reference, in-store comparison influenced final choice

6.1 Internal Factors

Across the six interviews, three dominant internal factor themes emerged. The first is habit and routine, which characterised the Category A purchases almost exclusively. Saurabh's Tropicana purchase is driven by a well-established habit loop, consistent purchase from the same store, reinforced by repeated satisfaction, with only minimal brand-level evaluation. This pattern is entirely consistent with Skinner's operant conditioning framework as applied to consumer behaviour: positive reinforcement (the satisfying taste of Tropicana) strengthens the purchase response, gradually reducing deliberation to near-zero over time (Schiffman et al., 2019). Rishabh's purchase, while also in Category A, bypasses even the habit mechanism, here, the internal driver is a raw physiological need, which in Maslow's (1943) hierarchy represents the most basic and urgent category of human motivation. When physiological needs are triggered in a constrained environment, purchasing behaviour becomes almost reflex-like.

The second internal theme is functional attitude, which dominated the Category B decisions. Both Shobhit and Brijendra were guided by a cognitive evaluation of product attributes, colour and pixel quality in Shobhit's case, brand reliability and after-sales service in Brijendra's. The Tri-Component Attitude Model (Schiffman et al., 2019) maps this well: the cognitive component (belief about product performance) and the affective component (positive feeling toward the Sony or Whirlpool brand) jointly produced the conative component (the purchase act). Notably, the affective component in Brijendra's case was derived not from direct product interaction but from the collective positive emotional experience of his social network, trust by proxy, rather than trust by experience.

The third theme is aspirational self-concept, which characterised the Category C decisions. Both Jay Kishan and Shivani made high-investment purchases directed at products they had wanted for an extended period, three to four years in Jay Kishan's case and six months in Shivani's. Sirgy's (1982) Self-Concept Theory is applicable to both, albeit in different ways. Jay Kishan's MacBook purchase aligns with his professional identity, a developer who owns the tools that the best developers in his peer group use. The purchase is an act of self-congruence: he is buying the product that matches who he believes himself to be professionally. Shivani's camera-driven decision is more product-performance focused, but the sustained desire, the patience to wait for the right model, and the emotional satisfaction of ownership are all hallmarks of an identity-adjacent purchase even when not consciously acknowledged.

6.2 External Factors

External influences showed a clear gradient across the three categories, minimal in Category A, moderate and family-centred in Category B, and indirect but professionally significant in Category C. In Category A, neither respondent cited any external social influence on their purchase. ⁷ This is consistent with the low-stakes nature of these purchases, the social cost of making a 'wrong' choice is negligible, which removes the motivation to seek external validation.

In Category B, the family unit emerged as the dominant external force. Shobhit's wife participated actively in the decision process, reflecting the growing trend of joint spousal decision-making in Indian middle-class households for significant domestic purchases. Brijendra's case demonstrates ²⁰ a different but equally powerful form of family influence, the collective endorsement of trusted relatives served as both an information source and a risk-reduction mechanism. This is informational social influence in its most classically Indian form: the joint family network functioning as a distributed research and validation system.

In Category C, external influence was present but indirect. Jay Kishan's developer peers influenced him not through social pressure or normative conformity, but through credible, first-hand product testimony, a distinction that Solomon (2020) identifies as the difference between normative and informational reference group influence. Shivani's family member performed a similar function, she did not tell Shivani to buy the Vivo X200, but her photographs demonstrated the product's capabilities more persuasively than any advertisement could. Both cases illustrate opinion leadership in action: influential individuals within a consumer's network shaping decisions through authentic lived experience rather than formal endorsement.

7. Comparative Analysis Across Categories

The table below provides a structured comparative analysis of the decision-making process across the three categories, mapped against the five-stage consumer decision model (Mothersbaugh et al., 2020) and supplementary dimensions drawn from the CBI course frameworks.

Decision Stage	Category A (Under INR 200)	Category B (Utilitarian, INR 10,000+)	Category C (Identity, INR 10,000+)
Problem Recognition	Physiological/situational trigger; spontaneous or urgency-driven	Functional gap, new household need requiring immediate solution	Aspirational desire, long-held goal or specification-driven want
Information Search	None to minimal; relies on memory, habit, and past experience	Extensive, 1 week to 2+ months; online reviews, store visits, word-of-mouth	Targeted, brand pre-decided; research focused on model selection within chosen brand
Evaluation of Alternatives	Very limited; 2 brands at most (Tropicana vs Real); zero deliberation in emergency	Multi-brand comparison across 3–4 options (Sony, LG, Samsung; Whirlpool vs others)	Brand-locked evaluation; competitors compared but rejected on price, OS, or specs
Purchase Decision	Immediate, at nearest available point of sale	Deliberate; timed with price comparison between online and offline channels	Delayed (waited up to 6 months); purchase triggered by financial readiness or model launch
Post-Purchase Behaviour	Satisfaction assumed; no active evaluation; repeat purchase confirms prior choice	High confidence; validated through use over time; no cognitive dissonance	Pride and sense of personal achievement; no public sharing; satisfaction sustained over time
Level of Involvement	Very Low	High	Very High (Functional + Emotional)
Primary Decision Driver	Habit, convenience, proximity, or urgent situational need	Functional performance, brand reliability, price-value ratio, peer recommendations	Product specifications, aspiration, family reference group influence
Reference Group Influence	Negligible, entirely individual decision	Moderate, family co-decision; word-of-mouth from trusted relatives	Indirect but significant, developer peers, family member who owned same product
Channel of Purchase	Nearest available physical outlet	Mixed: physical trial then online purchase for better price	In-store purchase after extensive physical comparison
Information Sources	Memory and past experience only	Online reviews, YouTube, physical store demo, word-of-mouth	Peer feedback, in-store hands-on testing, prior experience with brand ecosystem

Several cross-category patterns are worth highlighting. First, the depth of information search scales almost perfectly with price and involvement, from zero in Rishabh's emergency purchase

to two months of multi-channel research in Shobhit's case. This confirms the theoretical prediction of the ELM model that higher motivation, ability, and opportunity to process information produces more central route processing and more systematic evaluation (Petty & Cacioppo, 1986). Second, the role of the reference group escalates from negligible in Category A to structurally embedded in Category B (family as co-decision-maker) to professionally influential in Category C. Third, post-purchase behaviour reveals an interesting pattern: Category A consumers do not formally evaluate their purchase; satisfaction is simply assumed through continued purchase. Category B consumers actively validate their decision through use over time, Shobhit's year of testing his Sony TV across movies, games, and streaming is a clear example. Category C consumers experience satisfaction as ongoing emotional confirmation, every photograph Shivani takes with her Vivo reinforces the purchase; every time Jay Kishan boots his MacBook, the years of saving feel worthwhile.

8. Marketing Implications

² The findings of this study carry concrete ⁷ implications for marketing managers operating across each of the three product categories. The table below summarises strategic recommendations across five key marketing levers.

Lever	Category A Strategy	Category B Strategy	Category C Strategy
Distribution	Maximum outlet density; ensure product is available at every possible purchase point	Strong omnichannel presence; ensure both physical trial and competitive online pricing	Premium retail environment; experience-led stores; launch events
Communication	Sensory consistency; packaging must trigger automatic recognition at shelf	Content marketing; detailed spec comparisons; video reviews; expert endorsements	Aspirational storytelling; peer testimonials; community-building around product identity
Pricing	Price anchoring; avoid frequent price changes that disrupt habit loop	EMI options, seasonal offers, price-match guarantees to reduce hesitation	Premium pricing signals quality; avoid deep discounting which erodes identity value
Post-Purchase	Low investment needed; ensure product availability for next purchase	Robust after-sales service; warranty communication reduces cognitive dissonance	Unboxing experience; loyalty programs; invite customers into brand community
Reference Groups	Not applicable, decision is individual	Leverage family influencers and satisfied-customer testimonials	Target opinion leaders in professional/aspirational peer groups; developer or creator communities

For Category A brands, the findings reinforce a fundamental strategic truth: the habit loop is both the greatest asset and the greatest vulnerability. Brands like Tropicana that have established habitual purchase patterns must invest relentlessly in maintaining the sensory consistency and retail availability that anchor the habit. Any disruption, a price increase, a packaging change, a stock-out, risks breaking the conditioning and creating an opening for competitors. The Rishabh case adds an important distribution dimension: emergency or impulse Category A purchases are won entirely through placement. A brand absent from transient, high-footfall locations such as railway stations and bus terminals simply does not exist for this consumer segment at the moment of need.

For Category B brands, the Shobhit and Brijendra cases collectively make the case for a dual-channel strategy that acknowledges the hybrid nature of Indian high-involvement purchasing: physical experience first, online price-optimisation second. Brands that make it easy for consumers to touch, see, and test a product in store, while simultaneously offering the best online price, will capture both the sensory validation need and the value-seeking behaviour that

characterises this segment. The Brijendra case also underscores the untapped potential of word-of-mouth marketing programmes, structured referral incentives for existing satisfied customers could dramatically accelerate the information-to-purchase journey for new buyers, particularly in markets where digital review platforms are less trusted than personal networks.

For Category C brands, the key insight from both Jay Kishan and Shivani is that identity-driven consumers are often reluctant to acknowledge the identity dimension of their purchase, yet this dimension is precisely what sustains their loyalty and advocacy. Marketing communications that speak to professional aspiration, craft, and long-term value, rather than overt status signalling, will resonate more authentically with this consumer profile. Apple's consistent positioning of the MacBook as a 'tool for creators' rather than a luxury product is a masterclass in this approach. Similarly, Vivo's Zeiss lens partnership is effective because it grounds a prestige specification in a credible functional narrative, serious photography, not social performance.

9. Conclusion¹⁵

This study set out to understand consumer decision-making across three purchase categories through the medium of real depth interviews, and the findings exceeded initial expectations in both depth and nuance. The six conversations documented in this report are not simply purchase narratives, they are windows into the psychological, social, and cultural architecture that determines how Indian consumers navigate the marketplace.

Category A purchases revealed that consumer decision-making at the low-price end is far from mindless. It is either the product of sophisticated conditioning built up over months of repetition, or a lightning-fast situational response to an urgent need. Neither involves deliberation in the traditional sense, yet both produce decisive, confident purchasing behaviour. For marketers, this means that the battle for Category A consumers is won not in the advertising campaign but in the store shelf, the street corner, and the railway platform.

Category B purchases demonstrated that Indian middle-class consumers are discerning, patient, and increasingly sophisticated in their use of multiple information channels. They want the tactile assurance of an in-store experience and the financial intelligence of an online comparison. They consult their families, they trust their relatives, and they take their time. Brands that respect and support this process, rather than rushing or manipulating it, earn durable loyalty.

Category C purchases challenged perhaps the most fundamental assumption of the category: that identity products are bought for how they make consumers look. The evidence from this study suggests that Indian consumers in this segment are more likely to justify identity purchases through functional narratives, even when the aspirational dimension is plainly visible to an outside observer. This gap between stated and actual motivation is not a problem to be solved, it is a nuance to be honoured. Marketing communications that validate both the functional and the emotional dimensions of these purchases, without forcing the consumer to choose between them, will strike the most resonant chord.

In summary, this project has reinforced the core insight that underpins the entire discipline of consumer behaviour: people do not simply buy products. They buy solutions to problems, expressions of identity, validations of their place in a social world, and confirmations of the kind of person they believe themselves to be. Understanding this, deeply, empathetically, and without simplification, is the foundation of effective marketing.

10. References

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